

Closing Statement

a) Review of learning and teaching philosophies and goals set at the beginning of and throughout the year

The most prominent goals that I set at the beginning of the year were related to moving away from the traditional style of teaching that I experienced in school, and undertaking a more inclusive and constructive approach to planning lessons. Researching the constructive approach, I identified the importance of utilising problem-based learning, differentiated learning goals, mixed-ability grouping and peer learning. I also hoped to develop my questioning skills and my ability to integrate scaffolding into my practice.

In order to recognise my learning throughout the year, I expected to see learning and improvement reflected in each lesson plan that I prepared. I also placed an emphasis on reflective practice and decided to undertake a reflective journal.

b) Review of learning and development (addressing overall challenges, successes, personal and professional growth and learning)

Writing this closing statement at the end of my placement, I am glad to be able to identify personal and professional growth after overcoming challenges and improving my teaching ability throughout the year.

One of the most challenging experiences of the year, also gave way to one of the aspects of the year that I value the most. At the beginning of the year, I was overcome with anxiety on the morning of my first lesson. This stemmed from feeling out of practice in terms of teaching, and feeling daunted by preconceived opinions of teaching in a school that was 'difficult'. This battle with performance anxiety is something that I've improved greatly with throughout the year, and a big factor in this improvement is the relationship I developed with my co-operating teacher. Sensing my anxiety on my first day of teaching, my co-operating teacher went out of her way to encourage me not to give up, sharing her experiences of teaching and explaining that other teachers experience similar feelings.

I feel like my anxiety effected my teaching performance negatively at the beginning, I was pre-occupied with controlling the behaviour of the class and not adequately reflecting on my own performance. Building on my relationship with my co-operating teacher, I observed one of her classes once a week. This was an invaluable experience, it allowed me to see that even experienced teacher like her faced similar challenges. A key difference, however, was her ability to persevere through difficult interactions with

students. These observations, and my discussions with the teacher after each class, inspired me to improve my practice. I no longer ascribed difficulties in class to personal deficits, and saw instead different ways that I could improve my practice. This growing confidence translated into a more positive atmosphere in class, and the students responded to my positivity with their own. By the end of the year, I found myself growing more comfortable moving away from traditionalist teaching strategies, allowing students more freedom and designing lessons in more interesting and effective ways (e.g. Lesson 15 – student-led statistical investigation).

My strong feelings of anxiety returned at the end of the year during my teaching inspection. I expected very bad results, due to a lack of confidence. Thanks to my professional development throughout the year, however, I was told that my lesson was well-designed, that I showed effective questioning skills, and that I had a “great aura about” me while teaching. The main criticism was that I should work on my confidence. This is something that I can see has improved throughout the year and I look forward to improve on it in the years to come, by continuing to focus on carry out a reflective practice.

c) Reflection on your experiences as it relates to other modules and to the BA in Mathematics and Education as a whole.

Now that the year is over, I especially value this practical teaching experience for the challenging experiences I had in class. These experiences led me to try to find solutions in other modules, and I found very applicable research in my ‘Psychology, Sociology and Inclusive Education’ module. Important concepts like those of meritocracy, inclusive education, self-efficacy, and social class identity not only helped me overcome the challenges that I met in the classroom but also in my own academic performance. I have a reinvigorated appreciation for the theory that we learn, and am excited to continue to put it into practice in order to improve my own learning as well as that of my future students